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THE TIMES OF INDIA

Why splinter outfits fail to make an impact on Punjab electorate

TNN | May 15, 2024, 01.05 PM IST



Numerous political stalwarts, and some farmer leaders, in Punjab have tried to test electoral waters by floating their own splinter outfits after breaking away from mainstream parties in the past, but their sweat failed to make any mark.

In the run-up to 2024 Lok Sabha elections, at least two such splinter groups have merged with mainstream parties.

A former AAP MP from Patiala seat, Dr Dharamvira Gandhi, on April 1 merged his Nawan Punjab Party (NPP), into the Congress, which announced him as its Lok Sabha candidate from Patiala. Similarly, former Union minister Sukhdev Singh Dhindsa merged his Shiromani Akali Dal (Sanyukt) into the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) led by Sukhbir Singh Badal on March 5. Though Dhindsa

claims that his son and former finance minister Parminder Singh was promised a Lok Sabha ticket from Sangrur, SAD did not pick him. A look at other such groups launched by politicians and farm leaders in Punjab:

Apna Punjab Party

A former minister in Surjit Singh Barnala-led SAD govt elected in 1985, Sucha Singh Chhotepur — after he was ousted by Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) as its Punjab convener in Aug 2016 — launched Apna Punjab Party (APP) on Oct 1, 2016. All APP candidates forfeited their deposit in the 2017 assembly polls. Chhotepur joined SAD on Dec 9, 2021. A month later, APP merged into Sanyukt Samaj Morcha. Contesting on a SAD ticket, Chhotepur lost from Batala seat in 2022 assembly polls. In 2002, he won from Dhariwal assembly seat as an independent candidate.

Status | Merged into Sanyukt Samaj Morcha Lok Bhalai Party

A two-time SAD MP, Balwant Singh Ramoowalia, who became Union minister in 1996 as Rajya Sabha MP of Samajwadi Party (SP), launched Lok Bhalai Party (LBP) in 1999. He later merged LBP into SAD in 2011, describing it as his ghar wapsi. He again quit SAD and took oath as a minister in SP govt in Uttar Pradesh on Oct 31, 2015. Ramoowalia announced to revive LBP on Nov 24, 2021, in Ludhiana but failed to make electoral gains.

Status | Revived

Punjab Ekta Party

After quitting AAP, Sukhpal Singh Khaira floated Punjab Ekta Party (PEP) on Jan 8, 2019. The party unsuccessfully contested 2019 Lok Sabha polls from three constituencies — Khaira from Bathinda, Paramjit Kaur Khaira from Khadoor Sahib and Master Baldev Singh from Faridkot. Khaira, who is now the Congress candidate from Sangrur seat, got least number of votes (37,854) among PEP's contestants. Khaira rejoined Congress on June 3, 2021, and was elected MLA from Bholath constituency in 2022.

Status | Merged into Congress

People's Party

of Punjab Manpreet Singh Badal, finance minister in SADBJP govt, launched PPP on March 27, 2011, after he resigned over differences with SAD on the state's fiscal health. His splinter party drew a blank in 2012 assembly polls and he himself lost from Maur and Gidderbaha seats. Serving CM Bhagwant Mann also lost his election on a PPP ticket from Lehra constituency in 2012. In 2014, PPP forged an alliance with Congress and Manpreet unsuccessfully contested 2014 Lok Sabha election from Bathinda. On Jan 15, 2016, Manpreet merged PPP into Congress and won 2017 assembly polls as party candidate. Manpreet left Congress for BJP on Jan 18, 2023.

Status | Merged into Congress

AKALI REBELLION OF 2018-2024

Shiromani Akali Dal (Taksali)

A former MP from Khadoor Sahib, Ranjit Singh Brahmpura was expelled from SAD for anti-party activities in Nov 2018 during growing dissidence among taksali (senior) leaders against Badals. He and expelled Akalis — former minister Sewa Singh Sekhwan and former MP Rattan Singh Ajnala — launched SAD (Taksali) on Dec 16, 2018. Its lone candidate in 2019 Lok Sabha polls, Bir Devinder Singh from Anandpur Sahib, got fewer votes than Nota.

Status | Merged into SAD (Sanyukt)

Shiromani Akali Dal (Democratic)

Former Union minister Sukdhev Singh Dhindsa and son Parminder Singh were expelled from SAD on Feb 3, 2020, for raising a revolt against party chief Sukhbir Singh Badal. Dhindsa floated SAD (Democratic) on July 7, 2020, with Akali leaders who had left SAD. Dhindsa said his party will never ally with BJP, Badals and Congress. Party didn't fight any election.

Status | Merged into SAD (Sanyukt)

Shiromani Akali Dal (Sanyukt)

Brahmpura and Dhindsa merged SAD (Taksali) and SAD (Democratic) to launch SAD (Sanyukt) on April 19, 2021. Brahmpura became the party's patron and Dhindsa its president. Brahmpura rejoined SAD along with few other leaders on Dec 23, 2021. After a prolonged illness, Brahmpura (85) died on Dec 13, 2022. Dhindsa-led SAD (Sanyukt) contested 2022 Punjab assembly polls in alliance with BJP and Punjab Lok Congress (PLC) of former CM Capt Amarinder Singh. None of its 15 candidates could win and 14 forfeited their deposit. Dhindsa merged his party into SAD on March 5 this year

Status | Merged into SAD

DHARAMVIRA'S EXPERIMENTS

Punjab Front

In 2016, the then MP from Patiala, Dr Dharamvira Gandhi, was expelled from AAP. He announced a new forum — Punjab Front — by merging various splinter groups on Sept 26, 2016. All 15 candidates of this party lost in the 2017 Punjab assembly polls.

Status | Inactive

Nawan Punjab Party

Dr Dharamvira launched Nawan Punjab Party (NPP) on March 11, 2019. He unsuccessfully contested from Patiala in 2019 Lok Sabha elections and stood third by fetching 1.6 lakh votes. On April 1 this year, he merged the NPP into the Congress. His new party rewarded him with a ticket for the Lok Sabha elections from Patiala.

Status | Merged into Congress

CAPT'S 2 PARTIES

Punjab Lok Congress

After the Congress unceremoniously asked Capt Amarinder Singh to quit as Punjab CM, he tendered his resignation on Sept 18, 2021. He then launched Punjab Lok Congress (PLC) on Nov 2 that year. PLC entered into an alliance with BJP and SAD (Sanyukt) for 2022 assembly elections, but it could not win from a single constituency and lost the election deposit in 27 of the total 28 seats it contested. Capt Amarinder joined BJP on Sept 19, 2022, by merging PLC into the saffron outfit.

Status | Merged into BJP

Shiromani Akali Dal (Panthic)

A minister in the then SAD govt in Punjab, Capt Amarinder broke away from SAD and launched a splinter Shiromani Akali Dal (Panthic) in 1992. After his party failed to win a single seat in the 1997 assembly elections, he merged this party into the Congress in 1998. Later, Congress won the 2002 assembly elections and Capt Amarinder took over as chief minister of Punjab in Feb 2002.

Status | Merged into Congress in 1998

FROM FARM TO POLLS

Sanyukt Samaj Morcha

SSM was floated by 22 farm unions on Dec 25, 2021. Led by CM face and farm leader Balbir Singh Rajewal, who led the farmers' stir on Delhi borders against the three now-repealed central laws, SSM did not win a single seat in 2022 Punjab assembly polls. It fielded 94 candidates as independents as it couldn't be registered as a political party in time.

Status | Merged into Sanyukt Kisan Morcha. Condition includes not contesting elections

Sanyukt Sangharsh Party

Gurnam Singh Charuni, president of Bhartiya Kisan Union (Charuni) in Haryana, floated SSP on Dec 18, 2021.

SSP fielded 10 candidates in 2022 Punjab polls in support of SSM, but drew a blank. Charuni had earlier lost as an independent from Ladwa seat of Haryana in Oct 2019.

Status | Active, not fighting Lok Sabha polls, but plans to contest Haryana assembly elections

